Olivia Macanka

Dr. Barnshaw

EDUC 590

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Interview Activity

Part 1:

Interview Questions

Interview A: Adam Huenecke

Interview B: Paul Latka

Part 2:

Interview A Answers

Interview B Answers

Interview Questions

Below are the interview questions used for the activity. Some questions were individualized to the interviewee that are not listed here:

- **Could you tell me about your current role, responsibilities, and career path in the education sector?**
    - *This question is meant to help you understand the interviewee's job title, daily responsibilities, professional background, and how they entered the education field.*
- **What attracted you to this field?**
    - *This will help you learn what motivated the interviewee to work in education and what personal or professional interests influence their career choice.*
- **What does a typical week look like for you?**
    - *This question is intended to give you a realistic picture of the interviewee's daily work, schedule, tasks, and interactions with others.*
- **What is the name and mission of your organization, and what population does it primarily serve?**
    - *This will help you understand what the organization does, why it exists, and who benefits from its work.*
- **Who are your main stakeholders—students, teachers, families, schools, districts, colleges, or employers?**
    - *This question identifies the individuals or groups most connected to the organization and whose needs influence its work.*
- **How would you describe the organization's role within the broader education system?**
    - *This will help you understand how the organization fits into education and whether it supports students, educators, schools, families, institutions, or employers.*
- **Where would you place your organization within the education market?**
    - *This question is intended to identify what type of education organization it is, such as an educational technology company, curriculum provider, tutoring organization, assessment company, professional development provider, or student-support organization.*
- **How does your organization measure success?**
    - *This will help you understand which outcomes the organization values, such as student achievement, engagement, access, customer satisfaction, school partnerships, revenue, or other indicators.*

- **What does your organization believe is the biggest problem in education right now, and why?**
    - *This question is meant to reveal the organization's perspective on major educational challenges and the issues it believes are most important to address.*
- **How has technology impacted your company's operations, services, workforce, and ability to reach customers or learners? What benefits has it created, and what challenges or unintended consequences has it introduced?**
    - *This question focuses on both the positive and negative effects of technology, including changes in efficiency, accessibility, communication, employee responsibilities, artificial intelligence, privacy, cost, and personal interaction.*
- **What major trends or changes are currently affecting your organization and the part of the education sector in which it operates?**
    - *This question is intended to identify outside factors that are influencing the organization and the broader education sector.*

  What differentiates your organization from other organizations serving the same students, educators, schools, or customers?

    - *This question is meant to identify the organization's unique strengths, services, technology, research, pricing, customer support, educational outcomes, or approach.*
- **What advice would you give to a student who is interested in working in this part of the education sector?**
    - *This will help you learn about important skills, academic preparation, work experiences, internships, and career pathways.*
- **What changes do you expect to see in this sector over the next five to ten years?**
    - *This question encourages the interviewee to discuss the future of education, including technology, artificial intelligence, online learning, workforce needs, policy, funding, and changing student expectations.*

Interview A Transcripts: Adam Huenecke

Olivia Macanka: Okay, let me just share my screen. I've seen, like, some interviewers do this, and I kind of liked it. Sure. And that way you can kind of… as we go along. Could you tell me about your current role, your responsibilities, and career path in the education sector?

Adam Huenecke: Absolutely. So, I am currently the manager of the project management team for the CMS here at Modern Campus. And so, what that means is I manage 8 project managers, each of them manage between, you know 15 and 20 individual implementations, and so I do a lot of, not just, like management work, but a lot of, like, technical work jumping in and helping with, you know, kind of more challenging issues, either with, like, customer communications or technical pieces within the sites. So, I'm kind of the, you know, the troubleshooter in addition to the manager, and… The way I got here was I was a project manager at Modern Campus before I came into this position. Before I was here at Modern Campus, I actually started as a, college instructor, and so I taught history and social sciences, and, from there, ended up in the ed tech space when I went to, you know, away from the classroom to publishing at McGraw-Hill, and so I worked on their economics and finance textbooks for a number of years. As a part of that, you know, just kind of got into the, the ed tech space, which is what led me to the position here at Modern Campus.

Olivia Macanka: Hmm. Okay, so that kind of makes sense. So, is Paul one of the people that you supervise? Like, one of the… Okay, alright, now I'm starting to get a good idea of, like, how the org works, the org chart.

Olivia Macanka: What attracted you to this field? Especially, I guess, after you worked at a university?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I think, you know, I… I love higher ed. I love teaching. It's a challenging field right now, for a lot of reasons. There's a lot of change, there's a lot going on that makes it hard to… teach, both because there's hard, you know, there's not a lot of, roles available, and a lot of the pay isn't great, and so that's honestly what kind of nudged me toward the for-profit side of the business. And, you know, it's… I think education is obviously incredibly important. I think there's a lot of improvement to be made in the higher ed space, and we are at this point where things are changing so rapidly that, you know, within a few years, I think most. Colleges and universities are going to look different than they, you know, did For the past, you know, 10, 15 years. So, helping schools kind of navigate those changes, and then hopefully get into a better place is really, something I'm passionate about, and so it's, you know, something that makes it. Fun to wake up every day and try to, like, solve those problems.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. You know, it's funny too, because I was talking to Elyse the other day, and she was kind of echoing the same things you were saying too about higher ed. And so it's like, I think it's definitely a pattern.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, she had a similar trajectory. She didn't teach, but she was a she worked in, I think. Like the student affairs office or something like that.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah.

Adam Huenecke: So yeah, very, very similar trajectory there.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, and then what does a typical week like for you?

Adam Huenecke: Good question. Yeah, one of the things I really like about my job is that there's not…a typical week. Like, it's always something different. There's not… like, there is a routine in that, like, I log on at a specific time, and I have certain meetings that, like, I do…But every week is different challenges, especially in the role I'm in now. Like, I have no idea what problems I'm gonna be solving when I log in, what new problems are gonna pop up that I'll have to help come up with solutions for. But I love that. Like, I love that kind of troubleshooting.Both because it is different and challenging every single day, but, like, you see… you get that, like. it's gratifying to be able to come up with those solutions, and it definitely feels like we're making progress in a lot of different ways. So, you know, it's… I might get pulled into different meetings about contracts that we're working on with new schools. I might get pulled into a project manager who is having a challenge with something technical. You know, there's a lot of different things that, I end up kind of getting… getting pulled into, but it's not all reactive. Like, I do have time to work on some of our, you know, initiatives, and coming up with new product offerings, or changing some of our workflows to be more efficient, things like that. So, that's… that's kind of as structured as it could be. It is a lot of firefighting, but I think in a way that's really satisfying.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and just, like, personally, a quick question. Do you prefer the remote work? Is it something you enjoy more over in person?

Adam Huenecke: Personally, yeah, and I think because I mean, nothing about what I'm doing requires being in an office like there's nothing that would be helped by being in an office, and honestly, when I was in an office, I feel like both myself and a lot of other people are getting a lot less done, both in their, like, commute and in their actual, kind of, like, day-to-day, because there's more, I think, messing around that goes on. But it's…because I'm working with people all over the country like I start pretty early in the day, and then I, you know, go till sometimes a little bit later than you know. I think most people do. But, it's… you know, it kind of allows me to shift gears, and it's almost like. you know, playing a bunch of simultaneous games of chess, where you're just kind of like, I'm making a move in this, you know, board, and now I'm over here, and I'm moving on to this next board, where the physical space isn't really important, it's the ability to kind of, like, focus in on whatever the new problem is.

Olivia Macanka: Hmm. Okay, that's cool. Yeah, I feel like I'm so used to working in person that I don't really consider how efficient remote work is, and then my mom started remote working, and then I'm like, I like this life.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah.

Olivia Macanka: Absolutely now, it's really flexible, so…

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I think it's not for everybody. I think it suits me well, but I can definitely appreciate how some people, you know, kind of get more out of a, in-person experience.

Olivia Macanka: To your understanding, what's the mission of Modern Campus, and what population does it primarily serve? Like, who are your customers?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, so I know that there's probably an official version of the mission of Modern Campus. And it's you know, probably something along the lines of like, you know, to elevate every learner or something like that.And you know, at a at a high level. That's kind of what you know we're kind of aiming for. But to answer the question more broadly, like. I get to help people who are often really strapped for resources, who are trying to solve, like, really challenging problems of, like, getting people to find the programs that work for them, getting people to, you know, kind of get into school, and, you know, fighting the You know, careers that are gonna set them, you know, off in their entire lives and get them into these right places, often on a shoestring budget, often without the expertise that they need to like get these things done. I'm able to empower them to make those things happen. And it's awesome. And so, you know, it's primarily I'm working with college and university marketing and web offices.You know, those are the… for the CMS, those are the primary people that I'm working with. And so that's our our primary customer.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, I guess that kind of goes into the next question of who are your main stakeholders, but I guess, like, when you're talking… well, I guess expand on that, like, when you're talking to web offices, like, who is your point of contact? Like, who's, like, paying for this, too?

Adam Huenecke: Right, yeah, and so there's… that's kind of like a two… prong thing. So, like, we have the people that we work with every day, and so that, a lot of times, is, like, the, you know, webmaster or the web manager, everybody's got a slightly different title, but the person who's, like, responsible for actually updating content, you know, person or people, is usually not a very big team. But then they usually work with an office that'll have, like, a marketing director, and those are the people who kind of hold the purse strings, and are making, like, the high-level decisions, but aren't necessarily having to do, like, the day-to-day, like, content decisions. But they're also working with, you know, other directors, and they're working with school presidents, and they're working with, you know, different types of governing bodies that we end up kind of working with indirectly, and so we have to be aware of you know, you've been in higher ed long enough to know that there's a lot of politics, and there's a lot of you know, kind of consideration that every school's a little bit different, and you have to… you can't navigate, you know, every department exactly the same way, so there's a lot of…Soft skills of kind of understanding how people need to get things done, and then helping nudge them in the direction where they can, you know. Gregory A. make things happen effectively, even though, like, you're a third party, and you don't necessarily have the ability to, like, control everything, like, on a, you know.Adirect basis.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, like some expertise is needed from outsider perspective.

Adam Huenecke: Exactly.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, and then how would you describe the organization's role within the broader education system? So like, what's the part that Modern Campus and you play kind of in like the post-secondary world?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, so we… We basically work to enable those web and marketing teams to

Adam Huenecke: use our tools, whether it's, you know, the CMS or any of the other tools that Modern Campus offers, and then help them kind of find the most success possible with that. So some of it is just like, hey. you're going to be using our CMS for the first time. We're going to help you get it designed, we're going to help you get it, you know, working, we're going to teach you how to use it, and we, you know, take that kind of a train-the-trainer approach, where we're

not going to be doing all the work for you, we're showing you how to do the work in the future. A lot of schools don't have the luxury of being able to spend a lot of time on that stuff, and so we are expanding our services, and this is some of the stuff you've been helping us with, where we are doing more of the kind of content management. We are doing more of the day-to-day kind of web administration stuff. And so we… we both… Enable those aspects of people who are managing, kind of, like, the marketing site for the schools, and then also Supplement them with, like, additional, you know, kind of hours and expertise.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, perfect. So… The next question is, where would you place your organization within the education market? Like, what… I guess it'll be a little… elaborating a little bit more on, like. What products are you giving other than just, like, our CMS content work? And you were kind of talking about how you're expanding a little bit, into that other… those other elements.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah. So, you know, we are we're an ed tech company. Like, we create technology that's specifically designed for higher ed space. So specific like, there are other CMSs out there. Like, there's schools who use WordPress. There's schools who use Drupal and some of these more generic tools. But they're not designed for higher ed. So, like, everything we do is designed for higher ed websites to, like, solve the types of problems that higher ed encounters. So, like, at our core, we're an ed tech company. But beyond that, like, we're becoming a much more full-service You know, kind of… Part of a lot of schools where, you know, we are offering additional development help, or we're offering help in setting up marketing campaigns, or doing some of the other work that they might not have the… Actual employees, or the actual, like, people on staff to be able to kind of help with that. So not only, you know, do we help them use the, like I said, you know, a couple of questions ago, we help them learn how to use the tools. Now we can actually be the ones that are helping make all the content happen within those tools and making sure that they're getting the most of that too. It's not just EdTech now, it's also kind of, administrative support and. You know, helping them navigate the new world of AI and a lot of the other stuff that's kind of shaping how college websites are changing.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and I guess, like, what you're saying, too, is that your differentiator from other companies is that you're exclusively, like, within the post-secondary realm, like, whereas maybe… have you noticed, like, a lot of the other website development is just very standardized?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, a lot… there's a lot of tools that are just designed for websites in general, where there's only a couple companies, ourself, Hannon Hill. who really are specific to higher ed, and so we're not trying to be all things to all people. Like, we are really trying to do what higher ed does well. And beyond that, like, we do have more than just, like, our websites. Like, we do… Have things like, managing, student… communication via, you know, text message for, you know, admissions offices and student success offices. We do things like, catalogs for, both you know, regular you know, colleges and universities, so, like, most post-secondary stuff,

but a lot of, like, extended education now, too, is that's becoming, like, a broader market. So, you know, continuing ed, you know, that type of stuff, we have… platforms that allow for the, you know, both the catalogs and then the, like, registration and administering of those types of classes.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, great. And then, how does your organization measure success, or if you can't really speak, like, on modern campus as a whole, because I know there's a lot going on, like, how would you measure a successful year?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I mean, we're a for-profit organization, right? So, like, the way they're measuring it is profitability, but… I don't wake up every day and think about, like, how much money I'm making for other people, because that would be soul-crushing. Like, I… measure it by the number of schools that we're helping, the number of you know, new CMSs that we're, you know, getting people into our CMS, helping them get their sites, you know, up and running. So that's, you know, that's the way that we measure a lot of our success, is making sure that we're getting people their… time to value in a rapid way, so their projects aren't, like, taking forever. We're making sure that, like, you know, they're moving things along, we're managing them to, having their sites up and running, but also making sure that they're good. Like, not sacrificing quality, and then making sure that it's something that they're gonna be able to use on their own. Like, that they're not gonna just, like. Be done with their implementation and not know what's going on. Like, we want to make sure that they have that continued success, and we continue to support them throughout their. Their journey with us.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, so does that look like the customer is, like, always in feedback with the team about what they want, like, or are they kind of… Getting an end result, and then you change it as we go, or Like, and is there, like, a specific timeframe that they give you, or do you give them a timeframe, like a quote, basically?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, it's a little bit of both right, like we start off with a plan and you know, the first casualty of anything is the plan, and so we work to try to. Make sure that we're… delivering on as quick a timetable as we can, with the understanding that the resources that schools have are often pretty taxed. So, like, we'll make sure that the parts that we have control over are taken care of as quickly as we can, and that we're communicating to them, like, what needs to happen.But a lot of times, it'll come down to them just needing more time. And so it ends it starts with us, like, having, like, a goal in place where it's like, okay. If you wanna have your go live by, like, fall of 2026. But then the realities kind of take, you know, on, and they realize that, like, oh, well, you know, we're gonna need a lot more time to do that, so, like, okay, we're gonna push to… Spring of 2027, and so we're like, alright, cool, but we're gonna make sure that you actually get what you're paying for here. Like, we don't want to just have this last forever, we want you to have this new site that you're building. And so it ends up being kind of reciprocal, where, you know, we're helping them set you know, reasonable… deadlines, but then working with the realities of higher ed and the resources they have available.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. Well, that's interesting, though. That's, like, them normally pushing back the timeline. It's not kind of on our end that we need extra time or resources.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I mean, it would be a great problem to have. I wish that the schools had, you know, more time to dedicate to stuff, but that that what I was talking about with the services that we're offering now, too. Like schools just don't have the, they don't have the number of people that they need to make stuff happen.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and maybe that goes into the next question, too, of, like, what do you believe is the biggest problem in education right now, and why?

Adam Huenecke: That's a big question. If I had to pick just one thing, It's probably, like, the…it's funding is the… the number one thing, but that means a lot of things, right? Like. There's money that comes in from the government, from grants, and there's financial aid, but there's also just the way that, like, schools are spending their money, and, like, that's changing a lot right now. So…There was… there's been big shifts in kind of how schools need to balance their budgets, and they have to, you know, cut programs, or they have to consolidate campuses, and so…They're really in this… this kind of resource Rush right now to try to make, you know, get the most out of what They have, but they are kind of dealing with a lot of… Maybe kind of antiquated… Systems, in some cases, that, like… In the 1990s, when everybody was flush with financial aid money, like, this made total sense to have, like, a million people who do this different job, and the school's kind of like a low-key resort. But, like, we kind of can't do that anymore. But, like, you can't just, like, restart it. Like, you have to make the campus an attractive place, and you have to have all this other stuff, but, like, oh yeah, it's still supposed to be a school where we teach people things. And so it's that balance of resources with increasingly limited funding. And honestly, like, there's a big demographic cliff that's hurting that, where, like, there just aren't as many students. Not just people who can afford to go to school, but like... people… like, the number of people graduating high school is just not as large as it used to be. Just like demographically, it's not because they're not graduating, it's just like literally like a numbers game. So schools are gonna have to adjust to those realities. And so that's one of the big things that we're doing is trying to help people kind of optimize those resources.

Olivia Macanka: Oh my gosh, I'm so happy you said that, though, too, about the demographic cliff, because we were just learning about this the other week, how, like, one of the pervasive problems in education now is, like, that there's not even a lot of students because there's, like, a shortage in population, and it's interesting to see that play out, like, in real life, and you're also noticing the effects.

Adam Huenecke: Oh, yeah. No, you see it. I mean, it's… In addition to the fact that, like. We're seeing a lot of reduction in federal and state investment in higher education. And part of it is that, like, people… for, like, all the different, like, political stuff that's going on, they just don't view higher ed the same way that they used to, and people aren't convinced that it's, like, a good thing, and, like, so schools are kind of fighting an uphill battle to, like, make all this stuff happen. And honestly, like. You know, people are kind of in this mindset that they're just…you know, trying to get education to make money, and not to, like, enrich themselves, or to, like, make things better. And that… it's a hard situation, because then you don't have people getting a well-rounded education, so, like, the classic liberal arts model is really challenged. But there's a lot of value there. Like, you know, people need to know. You know, you… Try to think of, like, a nice way to say this. you should… It's good to know how to… be a…electric engineering. But you should also know that you shouldn't use your electric engineering to make, like, shock collars for Amazon warehouse workers, you know what I mean? Like, you need to know that what you're doing is actually improving society. And like the ways in which you know you could be creating damage. So, you know, that's kind of the ongoing… there's so many challenges, but…You know, picking just one is difficult, I guess. I have a lot of favorite challenges.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, yeah, it seems like it's… Kind of getting even more complicated, like, as time goes on.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, absolutely.

Olivia Macanka: And then, how has… technology impacted your company or your day-to-day life, in your ability to reach out to, like, different universities and, different, like, programmers, and is there any benefits, or, like, how… what's, like, the scale that we're looking at?

Adam Huenecke: Oh, gotcha, yeah. So the big one right now is AI. And…it's… this is another one that's incredibly complicated. I think there's two things going on. There's, like, the actual function of what AI can do, and then there's people's ideas of what AI can do, and they're completely different things. And a lot of people are sold on this idea that, like, it's AI is gonna be this massive efficiency tool and this, like, you know, force multiplier, and it's gonna, like, solve everybody's problems. And then when you get into it, and it's like, it is a tool. It is not a magic wand. It is something that… is… it needs to be used like a tool, and not, like, just kind of a, you know, automatic replacement for a lot of things. And so we're finding that, like, while some people, whether they're executives or schools, they want to use, like, AI as a magic wand to, like, solve their problems. that's just not how it works in real life. Like, we're looking at, like, our products, and, you know, we can have… developers not use any AI, and develop a website, and have it take, you know, with design and implementation, take, you know, 3 to 4 weeks. And then they can use AI, and dependent upon the needs of the school and the complexity, like, it can take 7 or 8 weeks. And it's not that it's bad, it's not that it's, you know, not working, it's just that it's

solving different types of problems. And so, just like anything, like…you know, It has specific applications. And so it's… it's part of it is mastering the technology because it is rapidly changing, but it's rapidly changing In a world where there's a lot of people who are really invested, both literally and figuratively, in it being a game changer. Hmm. And so, like, they're trying to force it in ways that it doesn't always really make sense. And so you're caught in this place where it's like, yes, we want to do the best things with the tools available. But we also need to be realistic about what this is, and not, like, oversell it, because it's not necessarily going to solve all of our problems.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And to your point, like, sometimes I think that AI is kind of, like, one of those things that's… it's now too big to fail. Like, we cannot let it go down, like, too much. And even, like. Some teachers at my school would try to use, like, AI to lesson plan, and it. It'll take longer because it just is not developed. Like it can't do it.

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, well, and that's… Part of it is, too, without getting too, like, off the beaten path here. Like, there's been a lot of people who have put a lot of effort into making AI look like it's too big to fail. Because they've invested a lot of money in it, and it never really became as profitable as they needed it to. And so now they kind of need it to be something that, like, oh no. It's so big and scary, the government needs to come in and bail us out, basically, because, like, our funding cycle isn't gonna work. And so, like, they're trying… you'll notice, if you pay attention, all the big scary stories about AI come from the AI companies themselves. And not, like, journalists, or, like, outside analysts. And this would be the only time in history that that's ever happened. It's like, why are you guys telling on yourselves so much? Is there a reason for that? And the answer is yes, and it's because they need it to be too big to fail, because if they were going to be honest about it, they'd have to admit that, like, it's not everything that they've… Sold it to be.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, a lot of stuff going on with the AI. I guess we can skip a little bit, because we kind of covered the next two questions. What advice would you give to a student, so I guess this is kind of directed to me, who is interested in working in this part of the education sector?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I mean… Do what you're passionate about, right? Like I think a lot of people are focused on, like, oh, I wanna, you know, get a job that's gonna make a lot of money, or I wanna get a job that's gonna, you know, have, like, a solid career path. But at the end of the day, like, you're gonna do the things well that you care about. And I've seen a lot of people who end up in positions when I was working with people in economics and finance that, yeah, they had jobs that like pay well, but they were miserable and like they did not like what they were doing. And honestly, they weren't putting a lot of effort into it as a result. But like, you're going to… do… A much better job at anything that you do, like, if you care about it. And so if you find yourself in a position where you're having to, like, really… Force yourself to, like, find ways to care, like, find something that you do. really… that really clicks with you, and that makes you

actually want to get up every day where you're not just worried about, like, cashing a check, but you actually do want to, like, solve these problems, because that's going to be the thing that you're going to be good at. And that's going to end up being the thing that you make a lot of money at, because you're going to be good at it. So that goes beyond just the EdTech sector, but.You know, that would probably be my best advice.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And it's also like, too, education really doesn't need people who hate education. So.

Adam Huenecke: Right. Exactly. Or, you know, if you're just here to just check, you know, just get a paycheck. Like.

Olivia Macanka: Okay.

Adam Huenecke: Don't bother. Like, there's plenty of things you can do that with, but, like, if you want to actually make a difference, like, and this is the field that you want to make a difference in, like, if you care about it, and, like, you want to see it improve, like, those are the people we need, because those are the people that are going to actually solve the problems that we've been talking about.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. Okay, last question. What changes do you expect to see in, like, let's just say, like, the education sector?

Olivia Macanka: in general, and even if you want to talk about specifically, like, within, like, post-secondary universities over the next 5 to 10 years? Like, an increase in consumers, like, a decrease?

Adam Huenecke: Yeah, I think it's gonna be different. Like, I think that people have in their heads, like, this…

Adam Huenecke: traditional student, like somebody coming fresh out of high school, and you know, doing the you know.

Adam Huenecke: 2- or 4-year degree of whatever they're trying to do, and that student is not going to exist in the same numbers that they used to. Like, we were just talking about with the demographic cliff, like, they literally don't exist as much anymore.

Adam Huenecke: Because we have so many changes in our economy and, like, technologically, people are needing to change careers, people are needing to, like, learn different things. So I think you're gonna see a lot more of what would have traditionally been called non-traditional students.

Adam Huenecke: And I think that that terminology is going to change, because ultimately, like, that's going to be your majority experience. But as a result, it's going to be less the…

Adam Huenecke: structured, kind of, like, 2- or 4-year degrees, and much more focus on things like micro-credentialing and certificates, and very, like, task-specific things, which I honestly think is great, because it's something that's long overdue. And at the end of the day, like, when I got my bachelor's

Adam Huenecke: Like, you had to pay extra to get your major put on your diploma.

Adam Huenecke: Because it didn't matter, like, really. And it's, like, well, yeah, you got your four-year degree, like, that's it. Like, it didn't matter what you did, you could have got D's in every single class, it didn't matter. You still got that same degree, and if you paid a little extra, they'd actually write your name… your major on it.

Adam Huenecke: And, like, who wants to hire that person? Like, you know, it shows no expertise, it shows no real understanding.

Adam Huenecke: just that piece of paper could mean that person was brilliant, or that person just showed up and got C's and D's for 4 years, and it wouldn't make any difference. So having that, like, micro-credentialing to show, like, yes, I did this degree.

Adam Huenecke: or I did the certificate, or whatever, and I can prove that, like, I'm actually experienced in this thing enough to, like, have shown some type of mastery of it. I think that's gonna be…

Adam Huenecke: something that we see across the board, and I think it's going to be a beneficial thing, because it'll…

Adam Huenecke: you know, both make education better for the people experiencing it, and for people as they're trying to, like, find the right people to fill roles, because they'll actually be able to show, like, yes, I'm trained in this, and I understand what I'm doing.

Olivia Macanka: Right, yeah, like, are you actually getting applicable skills.

Interview B Transcripts: Paul Latka

Olivia Macanka: I'll pull up on my screen, too, the questions as well. So, just, like, to your experience, too, and if you need to, change any… questions to fit your role, that's fine. But just to start off with, could you tell me about your current role, responsibilities, and career path in the education sector?

Paul Latka: Yeah, so currently I'm a project manager, so what I do is I help clients implement their content management systems, so they can start building out their websites. Funny enough, I worked at USF, so I was in the higher education side. I worked as their web content administrator. So I was pretty much maintaining and building out their web pages and their website. And then they were using OmniCMS, so I just pretty much went from them to Modern Campus to start implementing OmniCMS for other schools. I actually have viewpoints from both sides.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, yeah, so like that's kind of who your clients are now, right? Who you're working with?

Paul Latka: I'm actually working with my old team for one of the projects, so it's always nice to see them now.

Olivia Macanka: Oh yeah, that's really interesting. So, actually, I was talking to Adam and Elise about that, and they also came from higher education, so I'm just personally curious, do you see a lot of people from higher education kind of transition into these, like, private ed tech companies?

Paul Latka: Honestly, I've seen it more here than anywhere else, really. Kind of like you mentioned with Adam and Elise. I think it's always a good kind of segue, going from higher ed to someone who helps higher ed, because it's easier to bridge that gap.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, you kind of, like, know what they want.

Paul Latka: Yeah, and you know, like kind of their struggles of like internal politics and how slow or quick decisions are made on their side and everything.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And what attracted you to this field? So you started off in higher education. So like, did you always like higher ed or did you kind of pivot from something else?

Paul Latka: More pivot, I try and get, kind of, as much experience in every single field I can, so I went from, like, physical therapy to non-profit to higher ed to now a SaaS company. So yeah, I just want to try something new with being a web content administrator, I kind of had to manage my time and to meet deadlines.

Paul Latka: But being a project manager and taking on these kind of bigger roles and interacting with a bunch of different people from, like, directors and provosts and presidents down to, like, interns and all that just kind of helped me out with communication and just seeing a new side of things.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And then, so, what does your week look like? Obviously, you were doing the Monroe accounts, but is it always like that, or do you have other responsibilities that kind of make your schedule a bit more variable?

Paul Latka: Yeah, it's definitely variable, so… Here, we have kind of our internal stand-up meetings, where it's just the project managers. And then we have a separate meeting where it's the project managers, the development manager, and the design studio who does all the designs. So we use those meetings to kind of see what we're working on, if there's any projects coming down the pipeline, and just try and get developers lined up and ready to go to start working on projects. along with any kind of all ha- or all staff meetings, my company meetings, that get peppered in, like, every quarter or so. So you have those meetings, they happen every week, Tuesdays and Thursdays. Then you have all of your client meetings, so when a client goes through design and they're in development, you have weekly meetings with them. So every week, you're meeting with those clients. And then additionally, if you have a new project that gets, added in, then you have to schedule in, like, kickoff calls, and then schedule in the text box where you go through all of the designs to get them scheduled for development. Also, it's just a lot of, like, you have your core group, then you have all these additional meetings that you gotta fit in every day, so it changes week to week.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And just a personal question too, and I asked Adam this, do you prefer this like fully remote position or did you kind of have more success with in-person meetings?

Paul Latka: Oh, me personally, I love remote. I don't see myself ever going back into an office.

Olivia Macanka: Really, it's like, once you go there, you can't go back to the old ways.

Paul Latka: Yeah, I've been working remote since, I think, end of 2019, right before COVID. And it's just like all the time that you waste traveling to and from the office and all of that, you could be working already and just having like more work life balance too. So definitely love the remote work.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, I was thinking, like, how can I land a remote job after this? Because I hear so many good things about working remotely.

Paul Latka: Yeah, and honestly, it depends on the person, too, because, like, I like just kind of locking myself in the room and working, but if you need a lot more, like, kind of person interaction and, like, face-to-face, it might be difficult. But I just love the freedom of, like, I can take a meeting, and then if I have to throw, like, laundry in, I can do that, instead of having all that pile up for once you get home and you're already tired from the day and commutes and everything.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, no, my mom just went back to work full time. She worked for the government, so they were hybrid. Like, right after COVID, and she hates it. I feel so bad.

Paul Latka: Yeah, that's my sister. She calls me, like, leaving work every day, and she's like, yeah, I have to go in the office for no reason, because I can do this job at home. I'm like, yep, I feel for you, but I'm gonna keep my remote job.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, I'm gonna support you from over here on this side.

Paul Latka: Exactly.

Olivia Macanka: So we know, like, Modern Campus a little bit. What do you think the mission of your… of Modern Campus is, or, like, the mission that you portray through your role?

Paul Latka: I want to say it's just helping universities get as much, kind of, students and retain as many, kind of, students and graduate students and everything as possible, and just trying to make everything streamlined and easy, like. both for the university teams to get their jobs done, but also for any student that's looking at that university, and make sure they get all that information as quickly as possible.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, for sure. So do you think that The work that you do primarily helps students or administration? or kind of both.

Paul Latka: I would say… Both with leaning more towards administration, just slightly. Because the administration is technically who uses this product to kind of help target whatever students they need to get into the school, but if we didn't provide the administration the tools, then the students wouldn't get that information and be able to attend that school either. So, kind of help both, but I feel like we lean more towards administrations.

Olivia Macanka: And how would you describe the organization's role within the broader education system? So, like… For example, when it's supporting higher ed, do you think that it's… it's, like, a considerable market? Do you think that it's kind of a niche market? Is there room for expansion?

Paul Latka: I feel like eventually it's going to get into a niche market, because there's only so many, kind of, higher ed universities out there, and there's a bunch of different companies battling to get their business. Eventually. If you hit every single higher ed place, the next thing to go is, like, elementary and, like, kindergarten, like, grade schools, and start helping their websites. But at the same time, they don't really necessarily have to retain as many students as, like, a higher ed institution does. But right now, I would say niche.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And I don't know too, because would you see modern campus transitioning into K-12, or do you think it's kind of, a different market altogether, and they would need different tools?

Paul Latka: It's funny, like, there has been, in the last 2 years, slight hints. at, like, how that would happen, but I think that the tools are so, like. more different than what we do for higher education, that I don't know if there's too much of business in there, but at least that's coming from my perspective. I don't know how, like, senior leadership sees that.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, that's interesting, because it's like, I don't know really what… Elementary schools would need to develop externally. That would need like a specific function.

Paul Latka: Yeah, like, from what I see, it's like… elementary schools, you don't really pick your own classes, and once you kind of get through it, then you're off to high school. Like, you're not gonna go back for, like, a certification or, like, a graduate grade school course or anything like that.

Olivia Macanka: Right. Yeah. And then how we'll just ask, like, how do you measure success within your team?

Paul Latka: Yeah, within our team, I think the biggest thing as, like, project managers is to make sure that the project meets their deadline for whatever launch they schedule, and the most importantly right now is that everything stays within scope and within budget.

Olivia Macanka: Hmm. Is budget a concern that you're seeing a lot of?

Paul Latka: Here and there, it kind of depends on the time of the year. Like, there are kind of some Q4 holidays, everything kind of slows down, so schools aren't working as much. really not selling anything, and especially once schools are going through their budgets, you see it start to ramp up a little, so it's almost like a rubber band. Like, it'll get busy, then it'll kind of, like. Be flexible, slow down, and then we'll get busy again and stretch out.

Olivia Macanka: Okay? And then What does Modern Campus believe, or what do you believe we'll say, is the biggest problem in education right now, and why?

Paul Latka: I think, personally, from, like, some of the information I've been seeing. is, like, the younger generation, I feel like, are starting to realize that a 4-year education kind of I wouldn't say isn't needed, but maybe it's not as important as it used to be. That's why I see… or I've been hearing that people are going into, like, trade schools, and how Modern Campus works with two- and four-year universities. I don't know how that would kind of pivot into those trades programs. But I think it's just trying to get kids back into those four-year institutions is going to be a kind of big issue moving forward.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and it's interesting you say that too, because we were even talking about in my course. About, like, the business of education. It's called… we were talking about how, like, degree inflation is really impacting what students want out of their careers, and it's nice to kind of hear, okay, it's not just in the classroom or in a textbook, people are actually seeing it.

Paul Latka: Yeah, definitely, and it's like, I've seen or heard some people that got these $100,000 degrees, but they can only get a job for, like, $50,000 now, and it's like, they just feel cheated at this point.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, I know, and even with the student loans, that's gonna take forever to pay off. Depending on the rate, too, so… Yeah, I don't know. I guess it just depends on the person and the degree, but now, I guess, have you noticed people putting more time and effort into researching that, do you think?

Paul Latka: I haven't really seen it. I know, at least with us, we have that Pathways module. I don't know if you've worked with it, but that kind of shows you, like. or show the student, like, if they get this certain degree, what kind of job they can expect, what kind of salary they can expect. So I think we're kind of trying to bring that information to light more, so that students can make a more educated decision on what they want to pursue.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. And then, how has technology impacted your operations? And you can even talk about your personal experience with your team and, the services that you offer, and even, like, in the CMS, if there's been any updates that have been helpful or unintended negative consequences.

Paul Latka: Yeah, I think the biggest thing right now that I'm sure you've heard everyone talking about is just AI and trying to get all AI into this field. And we… I use it, like, here and there, too, mostly for, kind of, like. reviewing reports or saying what's different between, like, migration maps, and that's helpful. It makes it more efficient than going through line by line, so you just get the information quickly. But it's also, I feel like, gonna be a downside if you wanna… kind of push more into AI and have them replace certain positions. Like there's always going to be something that needs a person's touch, and you can't replace that.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. Do you know if Modern Campus has made any, or maybe you've heard like around somewhere if Modern Campus is trying to integrate AI into the CMS, or is that kind of like we don't really need that?

Paul Latka: There has been some clients that have brought that up for our product roadmap. I think we're at the early stages of kind of dabbling in it to see how we can incorporate it, but I haven't heard anything drastic on it yet.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, and then we did talk a little bit about AI, so if you want to expand on that, you're more than welcome to, but if you've seen any other major trends or changes currently affecting modern campus, or, like, the post-secondary clientele that we're working with.

Paul Latka: I feel like with that, at least post-secondary, there has been kind of more of a shift for personalization. So schools want to make sure that I guess users want to make sure that the schools are kind of seeing them and, like, catering towards what they want to see, which is where the personalization comes into play with us, because we can kind of target certain ads or, like, certain programs that someone has looked at, to kind of feed them more of that content. So I think that's where the big kind of item is right now.

Olivia Macanka: Do you think that's for retention, or do you think that's just kind of what the demand is for the incoming student population?

Paul Latka: I would probably say for retention, I feel like it kind of warms up the incoming students, where they just don't see themselves as a number and a tuition. It's like, oh, they're actually kind of taking notes on me to see what I kind of like.

Olivia Macanka: Hmm. And then, what differentiates Modern Campus, in your opinion, from maybe other website building or website developers serving, higher education?

Paul Latka: I think we're easier to use, like, our content management system. I… I don't know, I might be biased, because I've been using it for, like 8 years now, so I'm used to it, but I've helped clients move from, like, Sitecore and Drupal, and those systems seem so outdated, and just, like. extra steps to get one thing accomplished. So I just like the kind of simplicity and the clean layout of RCMS.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and then do you think that there's a lot of… just a personal question, because I'm curious, do you think there's a lot of companies in the market right now that are challenging modern campus in that way? Like, or is many of the competitors really out of date then?

Paul Latka: I feel like everyone is adapting, so there is more challenge, but at the end of the day, if we're all kind of battling each other to get the best product, then the end user is the winner on that. Like, even our, kind of, design partners are starting to incorporate some of the things we use, like managed services and be like a 1 stop shop. So we're even like battling other Cms providers, but also kind of battling our design partners as well.

Olivia Macanka: Hmm. That's interesting. So it's kind of like a two-way front, like a two-way battle.

Paul Latka: Exactly.

Olivia Macanka: Okay, and then last two questions, the first being, what advice would you give to a student, or I guess in this hypothetical scenario, me, who is interested in working in this part of the education sector? So, like, building out websites and for post-secondary.

Paul Latka: I would say if… It's something you like, definitely pursue it, but just be ready for kind of a hurry up and wait. Like, there's been projects where, we have… They had a strict go live. I gave them like a three month lead time on it. And then they had to get approval from like senior leadership and the president. And that three month safety net burned down to like a week

because it was hurry up. We got to do it. We got to do it. And then it was just stopped. So that's a lot of kind of shifting perspectives and goals that you're going to have to kind of deal with. But at the end of the day, like, I love working on a website. I like seeing, like, what I do live and be like, I actually did that. So if that's something you like, like the outcomes of, I would definitely pursue it.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah, and that's really interesting, too, because Adam mentioned that as well, that really a lot of the time delays are on the university side. Would you say that that's a problem that you're seeing a lot with clients, that maybe the infrastructure of post-secondary is slowing down the processes a lot that they want to accomplish?

Paul Latka: Definitely, like, I even saw that when I was at USF. It was a lot of red tape, and a lot of, like, we have to ask this person, and then get approval from this person, and get approval from our board, and it's like… they could have made this decision, like, weeks ago and been done with it, but yeah, you just have to jump through a lot of hoops to make those decisions.

Olivia Macanka: Yeah. Okay, last question. What changes do you expect to see in maybe the education sector, post-secondary sector, over the next 5 to 10 years? And I guess how… how modern campus will be affected by that? So, like, do you think it's going to get… better with the delays? You think it's gonna get worse, stay the same, the artificial intelligence, if you want to touch on that as well?

Paul Latka: Honestly, it's kind of hard to tell. Personally, I don't think it might be, like, a perfect storm. Like, if universities are really diving into AI, and they're trying to replace positions with AI, that's gonna… Increase those delays that someone's gonna have to review it to bring it to their team to make a decision to then get back to us for implementation. So I can see that being a delay. And kind of as I mentioned earlier with maybe students not necessarily wanting to jump into four year degrees, I think the kind of certifications or trade schools are going to start increasing. Instead, and then the four-year university is dropping, so it's just gonna be a lot of seeing where the trends go and seeing how we can pivot to accommodate everything.

Interview A Answers:

My first interview was conducted with Adam Huenecke. His title is manager, and he manages a team of eight at the company Modern Campus. Modern Campus sells a few different products but primarily focuses on building customized websites for post-secondary schools, and this is where Adam works within his department. Adam sees his work personally impacting students and helping them find the right paths for them within the post-secondary world. However, he primarily works with university marketing and web offices to create a shared concept that they would like to see for their website. While they work with both of those departments, Adam also noted that it's the marketing department that pays for the service and gives a budget that Modern Campus must work within. On average, Adam has seen this budget decrease amongst the university clientele he has worked with.

After interviewing Adam, one takeaway that made me pause is that the bureaucracy and the red tape involving college systems also impact the companies they work for, and that puts the colleges at a disservice. Adam has observed that it is colleges that push back their timeframe, rather than Modern Campus, mainly because they are not able to dedicate enough time to their part in curating the new website (sending over content to the Modern Campus team is one

example of their responsibilities). This problem stems from not enough labor within these departments to manage all of their priorities; therefore, many times the sentiment is that Modern Campus is trying to meet the deadline so that their university client is getting the most out of what they paid for and receive a live published website in a timely manner. The decrease in staff at these colleges echoes what we've talked about in class pertaining to the lower budgets. The reduction of funding and staff leads to the implications that universities may struggle to modernize their systems while trying to reassure students that their institution is worth the tuition costs.

Another point of conversation that stuck out to me was that Adam, after speaking with university staff, noticed there was a demographic cliff, which was also discussed as a fundamental problem in higher education currently. He specified that the issue was not only the lack of student population, but also that some students simply cannot afford to go. Modern Campus tries to serve universities in this regard by helping students and faculty "optimize their resources," so that students can get the most out of their time at their institution, and universities remain marketable and decisive in the education market, since their competition between other intuitions will be increasing based on lower demand and clientele. This commentary reinforced the idea that the amount of money within the education sector is reducing, and that the total market size may be reduced as a result.

After being asked about technology and AI, Adam was more skeptical about the role AI will play as a disruptor in the market. He believes that many people do not understand the limitations right now in the capabilities of AI. In his experience, AI has been useful as a tool but cannot replace the higher-level functions that are being demanded of it, currently. He notes that on the executive level, many people think that AI is a simple, straightforward solution to problems, even though it may make the issues worse. The example was brought up for those developers, who could finish a project in three-four weeks independently, would take them seven-eight weeks with the use of AI. From this portion of the interview, I ascertained that while there was a large push for AI development and implementation, it has not caught up with the market yet. While AI can code, the methodology and the timeframe do not align with the needs of consumers.

Modern Campus distinguishes itself from other organizations because their CMS system and their services are tailored to higher education. While other companies who work with post-secondary schools often use tools that are built for general website design, only a handful of companies have the CMS ecosystem built for universities. These systems often factor in student communication and course catalogs that other companies do not have the technological capacity or bandwidth to incorporate into their service offerings. The aspects of Adam's role that I find interesting are how he works with the university departments to conceptualize new websites and how he must work within the parameters of the schools' budget and find creative solutions to any content migration issues. I find that having boundaries makes people more creative in their jobs, which I would want to see reflected in my own career. This conversation has expanded my interest in the edtech industry because of the flexibility and variability in schedule and projects.

Interview B Answers:

For this interview, I spoke with Paul Latka. He was a project manager at Modern Campus while the interview was conducted. While both interviewees work for Modern Campus, Paul works primarily on the content migration and website design itself, and he works with the Modern Campus internal design studio, along with the other project managers. From his position, he sees Modern Campus' services deployed slightly more toward the benefit of administration, as they work to retain students during the plateau of the population attending university.

During his interview, Paul elaborated on and gave key insights into the educational market that they serve. He has perceived that because Modern Campus serves a tailored market, that eventually there will not be enough growth within the company. Interestingly, there have been talks within upper administration at Modern Campus surrounding expanding their reach and demographics to cater towards K-12 schools. While senior leadership is trying to make the transition towards K-12 seamless, Paul expresses concern with the idea, saying that their higher ed SaaS models are not necessarily compatible with what would be offered in the elementary and secondary levels. The implication would be that if the administration wanted to move towards younger demographics, they would have to reconfigure their products to meet demand. From this topic, I concluded that the higher education potential is more limited that I previously thought,

with a limited customer base being a real threat, coupled with other pervasive issues already established in the industry (budget, population, etc.).

Although Adam labeled budget and the demographic cliff as the largest issues in education, Paul believes that the lack of consumer confidence in traditional four-year institutions is the main pain point for higher education. He referred to the rise in popularity in trade schools, as well as the substantial cost increase for the same degree over time. He also briefly discussed micro credentialing as another significant deviation away from the traditional college pathway. The discrepancy between these two answers can be explained by the fact that Adam works primarily with the post-secondary clients and management on the budgets/ contracts for their projects, while Paul works more closely on the student facing components. However, this does not mean that one issue is mutually exclusive to the other. Based on our discussion in class, these problems culminate and feed into one another. These factors indicate that universities have and will continue to struggle with these core dilemmas for the foreseeable future, as the buyer pool becomes more inhibited over time.

Finally, Paul spoke about the shift towards individualizing the higher educational space. The shift tells a story about how universities try to combat the criticism about degree inflation. Paul has noticed that universities have been trying to personalize and modify their websites, theoretically to appeal to more niche aspects of university involvement initiatives. Also, the more a website is customized, the more it costs the client. The push towards a customizable student experience denotes the growing concerns that without a tailored journey and outcome, students will continue to go down nontraditional routes, which inhibits the institution's account of receivable revenue. The implication of these actions is that universities will have to continue to adjust their curriculum to better meet the distinct needs of the student body, though it will be time intensive and costly over a longer duration of time.

As for differentiation, Paul elaborated that the Modern Campus CMS is easier to use as an employee compared to other companies. That simplicity in design and format helps employees perform more creative and innovative functions in a time effective manner. I am glad Paul brought this insight into perspective, because oftentimes I do not hear about the employee experience with tools, and the focus is diverted almost entirely to the consumer experience. However, the satisfaction of employees and the reliability of the tool provided to them can also streamline one's business and have an impact on morale and production within the company.

Paul's role interested me because he worked in the design and migration process and had more creative freedom compared to Adam's role. He still was able to work with clients directly but has much of his time dedicated to working on and leading the website development and design element. After my interview with Paul, I think this portion of the education sector sounds more appealing, since it offers hands-on work, whereas other roles are more tasked and management oriented. While the specific post-secondary market may be too volatile, I enjoy the idea of working in web design for other divisions in the educational industry.